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## Why are heterosexuals guilty toward homosexuals?

### Introduction

This article seeks to critically examine the often-overlooked moral and societal responsibilities of heterosexuals toward LGBTQ+ communities, using Germany as a case study. While many perceive Western societies—particularly Germany—as progressive and accepting, this perception tends to gloss over persistent systemic biases, historical injustices, and cultural attitudes that continue to marginalize homosexual individuals. The discussion will explore the historical context of Germany’s relationship with homosexuality, societal fears and misconceptions, institutional roles, and the cultural norms that sustain invisibility and discrimination. By analysing these facets, the article aims to argue that genuine societal progress requires more than legal rights; it demands an acknowledgment of collective responsibility, moral reflection, and active efforts toward inclusion and equality.

### Challenging Perceptions of Progress

A widespread impression persists globally that Western societies are more progressive and accepting of homosexuality and LGBTQ+ communities than other regions.<sup>1</sup> Many heterosexuals, as well as members of the LGBTQ+ community itself, tend to believe that the West exhibits greater tolerance and openness.<sup>2</sup> However, this perception warrants critical examination. This article aims to explore this assumption through a nuanced analysis, focusing specifically on Germany.

### Contemporary Debates and societal focus

Recently, in an article titled “Liebe LGBTQ – geht es ein wenig leiser?” (“Love LGBTQ – Can it be a Little Quieter?”) published in *WELT*, author Jacques Schuster expressed frustration with the pervasive media presence and societal emphasis on LGBTQ+ topics.<sup>3</sup> While respecting the rights of LGBTQ+ individuals to live authentically is vital, Schuster contended that the persistent focus on these issues can be excessive. He argued that such constant emphasis might not accurately reflect the experiences of the majority heterosexual population, which may feel underrepresented or unaffected by societal spotlight. Ultimately, he called for a more balanced portrayal and a reduction in societal emphasis on LGBTQ+ matters.<sup>4</sup> His perspective echoes a common sentiment among many heterosexuals, suggesting that society’s current focus on LGBTQ+ issues may be disproportionate, yet acknowledging that it also has historical roots.

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<sup>1</sup> Silvestre Cabrera, M., Royo Prieto, R., & Aristegui Fradua, I. (2024). Attitudes towards Homosexuality in Europe: Analysis of the European Values Study. *Sexes*, 5(2), 148-162. <https://doi.org/10.3390/sexes5020011> (Accessed September 18, 2025).

<sup>2</sup> Silvestre Cabrera, Royo Prieto, & Aristegui Fradua (2024).

<sup>3</sup> Schuster, J. (2025, September 13). Liebe LGBTQ – geht es ein wenig leiser? *WELT*. <https://www.welt.de/debatte/article68c3ec10f313976149c6d042/Liebe-LGBTQ-geht-es-ein-wenig-leiser.html> (Accessed September 18, 2025).

<sup>4</sup> Schuster (2025).

## Historical Context and Societal Attitudes in Germany

Germany's history with homosexual rights is complex and fraught with trauma—from persecution during the Nazi era to ongoing discrimination in the post-war period.<sup>5</sup> These historical experiences have left deep scars, contributing to persistent prejudices and systemic bias against LGBTQ+ individuals.

### Resilience of Deep-Rooted Beliefs

Contemporary social perceptions of homosexuality remain significantly shaped by conservative and traditional values that often regard it as taboo.<sup>6</sup> These deeply rooted beliefs are resilient, posing significant obstacles to full societal acceptance even in the face of progressive legislation.<sup>7</sup> Sexual orientation is still not incorporated in the Basic Law.<sup>8</sup> As a result, many heterosexual individuals tend to conceal their true attitudes towards LGBTQ+ issues, maintaining a veneer of tolerance while harbouring underlying bias.

### Societal Fears and Misconceptions

A prevalent concern among heterosexuals worldwide including in Germany is the fear that granting greater acceptance and rights to homosexuals might threaten societal continuity or even lead to the extinction of the heterosexual population.<sup>9</sup> This irrational fear persists despite legal protections and societal progress. Often, this fear is spread and supported by conservative and right-wing groups, which influence laws and beliefs, even though their worries are not logical or true.<sup>10</sup> The left-wing political factions have made limited contributions toward the empowerment of LGBTQ+ individuals; their actions appear predominantly motivated by external pressure from activists for strategic or political purposes.<sup>11</sup> Furthermore, their approach tends to be diplomatic, often concealing underlying homophobic sentiments.

### Historical Religious and Moral Condemnation

Historically, religious doctrines condemned homosexuality as a moral sin, leading authorities to criminalize it.<sup>12</sup> Society at large once regarded homosexuality as a disease, curse, or crime, fostering widespread disapproval and social exclusion.<sup>13</sup>

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<sup>5</sup> Franklin, R. (2011). Warm brothers in the boomtowns of hell: The persecution of homosexuals in Nazi Germany. *Hohonu Journal of Academic Writing*, 9, 56.

<sup>6</sup> OECD (2023), The Road to LGBTI+ Inclusion in Germany: Progress at the Federal and Länder Levels, OECD Publishing, Paris, <https://doi.org/10.1787/977b463a-e> (Accessed September 18, 2025).

<sup>7</sup> OECD (2023).

<sup>8</sup> OECD (2023).

<sup>9</sup> Bayrakdar, S., & King, A. (2021). LGBT discrimination, harassment and violence in Germany, Portugal and the UK: A quantitative comparative approach. *Current Sociology*, 71(1), 11–33. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00113921211039271>.

<sup>10</sup> Boulila, S. C., Marienfeld, A., & Wellner, F. (2024). Post-homophobic imaginaries amongst the far-right in Germany and Switzerland. *Identities*, 32(5), 676–694. <https://doi.org/10.1080/1070289X.2024.2406630>.

<sup>11</sup> Boulila, Marienfeld, & Wellber, (2024).

<sup>12</sup> Gross, M. (2008). To be Christian and homosexual: From shame to identity-based claims. *Nova Religio: The Journal of Alternative and Emergent Religions*, 11(4), 77–101. <https://doi.org/10.1525/nr.2008.11.4.77>.

<sup>13</sup> Saeed, S., Ahmed, J., & Qasab, Z. (2024). Homosexuality: A scientific view. *Pharmacology Medical Reports Orthopedic and Illness Details (Comorbid)*, 3, 17. <https://doi.org/10.55047/comorbid.v3i4.1474>.

## Shared Responsibility for Oppression

If many scholars agree that oppressors such as individuals, regimes, or nations must be held accountable for atrocities like Nazi crimes, racism, and colonialism,<sup>14</sup> then it is logical to question why the same moral logic cannot be extended to the heterosexual community. Since the majority of society is heterosexual, and most remain passive or complicit in systemic oppression, they share responsibility for perpetuating inequality.

## Systemic Discrimination and Heteronormativity

### Heteronormativity as a Source of Systemic Discrimination

Heteronormativity, rooted in religious, legal, and societal norms,<sup>15</sup> is a primary source of systemic discrimination. Recognizing this, it follows that society, especially those in positions of power, bears moral responsibility to address and rectify these enduring injustices<sup>16</sup>—not to blame individuals, but to acknowledge the collective legacy of inequality that continues to marginalize LGBTQ+ people.

### Progress and Persistent Injustices

Human progress, including technological advances like smartphones, has transformed social interactions, yet many historical injustices persist. Historically, heterosexuals have rarely understood homosexuals empathetically or accurately. It has taken centuries and ongoing efforts to deepen this understanding, and the process remains incomplete.<sup>17</sup> The relationship between heterosexuals and homosexuals has long been characterized by tension, rejection, intolerance, and invisibility patterns that persist today.<sup>18</sup> While issues and circumstances have evolved, the core problem of misunderstanding remains constant. Homophobia has manifested in various forms over time, often resulting in societal rejection and the marginalization of LGBTQ+ individuals.<sup>19</sup> Today, many heterosexuals continue to attempt to “invisibilise”<sup>20</sup> or deny the presence of homosexuals, perpetuating a climate of silence and neglect.

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<sup>14</sup> Carsten Stahn, Piercing the Colonial Veil? Colonial Crimes as Crimes against Humanity, *Journal of International Criminal Justice*, 2025, mqaf022, <https://doi.org/10.1093/jicj/mqaf022>, Murray, S. (2017). *Understanding Atrocities: Remembering, Representing and Teaching Genocide*. Calgary: University of Calgary Press. <https://doi.org/10.1515/9781552388877>.

<sup>15</sup> Zehra, F., Nur, A. N., & Melike, Z. E. (2023). Religion and attitudes towards sexual orientation and gender identity. *Journal of Religious and Religious Dynamics*, 2(1), 27–42. <https://doi.org/10.58425/jrcd.v2i1.210>.

<sup>16</sup> Spinner-Halev, J. (2007). From historic to enduring injustice. *Political Theory*, 35(4), 574–597. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0090591707304585>.

<sup>17</sup> Silvestre Cabrera, Royo Prieto, Aristegui Fradua, (2024).

<sup>18</sup> Schope, R. D., & Eliason, M. J. (2000). Thinking versus acting: Assessing the relationship between heterosexual attitudes and behaviors towards homosexuals. *Journal of Gay & Lesbian Social Services: Issues in Practice, Policy & Research*, 11(4), 69–92. [https://doi.org/10.1300/J041v11n04\\_04](https://doi.org/10.1300/J041v11n04_04).

<sup>19</sup> Schope, & Eliason, (2000), see Ray, T. N., & Parkhill, M. R. (2021). Heteronormativity, disgust sensitivity, and hostile attitudes toward gay men: Potential mechanisms to maintain social hierarchies. *Sex Roles*, 84(1-2), 49–60. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11199-020-01146-w>.

<sup>20</sup> Ray, & Parkhill, (2021).

## Invisibility and Misunderstanding of Homosexuality

### Roots of Invisibility and Denial

The root causes of this invisibility include indifference and insensitivity. Most heterosexuals misunderstand or only partially understand homosexuality, while others lack understanding altogether.<sup>21</sup> Heterosexual men tend to exhibit greater insensitivity and harbor more negative attitudes toward homosexual men compared to women. However, a considerable proportion of women are also complicit in this phenomenon, as their capacity to intervene is often limited, leading them to tacitly endorse or support male-related attitudes and behaviours.<sup>22</sup> The degree of awareness varies across different groups, shaped by diverse cultural, social, or personal reasons.<sup>23</sup> These misconceptions are not confined to the general public, they extend to professionals such as doctors, therapists, judges, and educators.<sup>24</sup>

### Institutional Roles and Responsibilities

Institutions like law enforcement, the judiciary, and the medical community bear collective responsibility for centuries of systemic repression.<sup>25</sup> Predominantly led by heterosexual professionals, these institutions have historically misunderstood or stigmatized homosexuality, reinforcing a legacy of prejudice.<sup>26</sup> While earlier repression involved overt violence, modern approaches often disguise suppression beneath superficial compassion—maintaining control through subtle means.

### Superficial Advocacy and Education Gaps

The concept of political correctness in advocating for LGBTQ+ rights often masks superficial or strategic efforts rather than genuine understanding. Various domains social, legal, economic, scientific are interconnected and have historically influenced each other, sometimes perpetuating misinterpretations. For example, legal systems have often reflected prevailing social or political biases, and economic considerations have generally been marginalized in discussions of sexuality.<sup>27</sup> Overall, these domains have demonstrated shortcomings in fully understanding and accepting homosexual individuals.

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<sup>21</sup> Ray, & Parkhill, (2021).

<sup>22</sup> Ray, & Parkhill, (2021).

<sup>23</sup> Borooah, V. (2021). *Prejudice: Xenophobia, homophobia, and patriarchy in the world* (MPRA Paper No. 113065). University Library of Munich, Germany.

<sup>24</sup> Arslantas, I., Inan, G., Gokdemir, O., Dagbagli, G., & Mustan, K. (2022). Homophobia among medical faculty members. *Journal of Continuing Education in the Health Professions*. <https://doi.org/10.1097/CEH.0000000000000435>; Bowers, R., Plummer, D., & Minichiello, V. (2005). Homophobia in counselling practice. *International Journal for the Advancement of Counselling*, 27, 471–489. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10447-005-8207-7>; Boucai, M. (2005). A legal remedy for homophobia: Finding a cure in the international right to health. *Georgetown Journal of Gender and the Law*, 6(21). <https://ssrn.com/abstract=2544881>; Leonard, A. S. (1991). From law: Homophobia, heterosexism, and judicial decision making. *Journal of Gay & Lesbian Psychotherapy*, 1(4), 65–91. [https://doi.org/10.1300/J236v01n04\\_05](https://doi.org/10.1300/J236v01n04_05).

<sup>25</sup> Spinner-Halev, J. (2007). From historic to enduring injustice. *Political Theory*, 35(4), 574–597. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0090591707304585>.

<sup>26</sup> Arslantas, Inan, Gokdemir, Dagbagli, & Mustan, (2022).

<sup>27</sup> Martell, M. E., & Roncolato, L. (2023). Economic vulnerability of sexual minorities: Evidence from the US Household Pulse Survey. *Population Research and Policy Review*, 42(2), 28. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11113-023->

Education has played a limited role in fostering comprehensive understanding.<sup>28</sup> Although LGBTQ+ rights are recognized in Germany, the community remains largely invisible outside of events like the annual Pride parade, which often adopts a festive, carnival-like atmosphere. In private life and online spaces, LGBTQ+ individuals are often unnoticed or marginalized, reflecting societal reluctance to openly acknowledge diverse sexual identities.<sup>29</sup> This invisibility stems partly from superficial efforts motivated by political or social pressures rather than authentic compassion. Without genuine empathy, full societal acceptance remains elusive.<sup>30</sup> Achieving true equality demands more than legal recognition; it requires heartfelt understanding and acceptance.

### Public Attitudes and Societal Acceptance

Public attitudes often reflect superficial compliance rather than genuine acceptance. Heteronormativity has historically imposed its standards through coercion, with demands for equality met by resistance or delays.<sup>31</sup> As a result, societal change tends to be imposed rather than naturally embraced, hindering progress. The collective consciousness of heterosexual people often appears unprepared or unwilling to fully recognize LGBTQ+ visibility.<sup>32</sup> Compared to other marginalized groups, such as refugees, people with disabilities, women, or Muslims—LGBTQ+ issues receive less open acknowledgment.<sup>33</sup> This reflects deeper biases and societal priorities that favor certain groups over others.

### Superficial Responses and Continued Misconceptions

Responses to LGBTQ+ issues are often mechanical, lacking genuine emotional engagement and tend to mimic heterosexual family models rather than understanding diverse sexual orientations.<sup>34</sup> This superficiality hampers authentic acceptance. Many misconceptions persist, such as viewing homosexuality as mere promiscuity or immorality, which heterosexual society disapproves of. Once legal rights are secured, many assume the problem is resolved, dismissing ongoing efforts for acceptance, inclusion and visibility.<sup>35</sup> Germany's current situation reflects this pattern.

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09778-y, see Badgett, M. V. L., Waaldijk, K., & van der Meulen Rodgers, Y. (2019). The relationship between LGBT inclusion and economic development: Macro-level evidence. *World Development*, 120, 1–14. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.worlddev.2019.03.015>.

<sup>28</sup> OECD (2023).

<sup>29</sup> OECD (2023).

<sup>30</sup> Mandracchia, F., Raghavan, A., & Gonzales, L. (2023). Empathy as a resilience factor in lesbian, gay, and bisexual individuals: A scoping review. *GLQ: A Journal of Lesbian and Gay Studies*, 28. <https://doi.org/10.1080/19359705.2023.2239725>.

<sup>31</sup> Gross, M. (2008). To be Christian and homosexual: From shame to identity-based claims. *Nova Religio: The Journal of Alternative and Emergent Religions*, 11(4), 77–101. <https://doi.org/10.1525/nr.2008.11.4.77>.

<sup>32</sup> OECD (2023).

<sup>33</sup> Center for Intersectional Justice. (2019). *Intersectional discrimination in Europe: Relevance, challenges and ways forward*. European Network Against Racism. [https://www.intersectionaljustice.org/img/intersectionality-report-FINAL\\_yizq4j.pdf](https://www.intersectionaljustice.org/img/intersectionality-report-FINAL_yizq4j.pdf) (Accessed September 22, 2025).

<sup>34</sup> Hanssen, J. (2012). 'My Rainbow Family'—Discomfort and the heteronormative logics. *Young*, 20, 237–256. <https://doi.org/10.1177/110330881202000302>.

<sup>35</sup> Flores, A., & Park, A. (2018). Examining the relationship between social acceptance of LGBT people and legal inclusion of sexual minorities. <https://doi.org/10.13140/RG.2.2.29750.34880>.



## Legal Rights and Societal Perceptions

Most Germans<sup>36</sup> perceive LGBTQ+ visibility as unnecessary, considering sexuality a private matter. They believe that personal sexual choices should be kept private and not publicly discussed. In contrast, heterosexuals often openly share their family and personal lives, reinforcing a societal norm<sup>37</sup> that sees LGBTQ+ visibility as unwarranted or intrusive. This attitude reflects a broader cultural tendency among heterosexual Germans to avoid discussing sexuality altogether, emphasizing traditional family roles, marriage and children over personal sexual identities.<sup>38</sup> Such beliefs implicitly discourage LGBTQ+ individuals from openly sharing their lives in public or professional spheres, often driven by underlying fears and biases. Unfortunately, these attitudes have obstructed progress and empowerment within LGBTQ+ communities.

Reversing this dynamic highlights its irrationality: if a homosexual individual requested a heterosexual person to keep their private life private at work or in public, it would likely be viewed as abnormal or inappropriate. Deep-seated biases also persist, with most heterosexuals subconsciously perceiving LGBTQ+ individuals as "disordered" or abnormal.<sup>39</sup> Most claim to endorse liberal values out of fear of being labelled conservative, resulting in superficial expressions of tolerance or performative liberalism. Despite Germany's high literacy rate, the country is not actively promoting LGBTQ+ visibility.<sup>40</sup>

## Education, Politics, and Societal Dynamics

The German education system frequently falls short in effectively addressing or challenging prejudices against homosexuality starting from primary school. LGBTQ+ students frequently face bullying, and curricula rarely include comprehensive discussions of sexuality. LGBTQ+

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<sup>36</sup> In my article, I employ the terms "most Germans" or "most heterosexuals" when presenting my arguments, rather than "many Germans," "some," or "few." This choice reflects the reality that LGBTQ+ visibility has not achieved the same prominence in mainstream society as heterosexual visibility, regardless of the underlying reasons. Such a disparity suggests that the majority of heterosexual individuals have not fostered an environment conducive to full visibility and acceptance of homosexual individuals. Consequently, many homosexuals do not feel comfortable appearing publicly, a situation primarily attributable to the prevailing dominance of heterosexuality and patriarchal social structures. Utilizing terms like "some," "few," or "many" would be less accurate and may serve more as a form of political correctness or diplomatic politeness aimed at pleasing the heterosexual majority, rather than accurately representing the societal dynamics at play.

<sup>37</sup> Hank, K., & Salzburger, V. (2015). Gay and lesbian adults' relationship with parents in Germany: Gay and lesbian adults' relationship with parents. *Journal of Marriage and Family*, 77(6), 1235–1248. <https://doi.org/10.1111/jomf.12205>.

<sup>38</sup> Hanssen, J. (2012). 'My Rainbow Family'—Discomfort and the heteronormative logics. *Young*, 20, 237–256. <https://doi.org/10.1177/110330881202000302>, Hank, K., & Salzburger, V. (2015). Gay and lesbian adults' relationship with parents in Germany: Gay and lesbian adults' relationship with parents. *Journal of Marriage and Family*, 77(6), 1235–1248. <https://doi.org/10.1111/jomf.12205>, see Bohr, J., & Lengerer, A. (2024). Partnership dynamics of LGB people and heterosexuals: Patterns of first partnership formation and first cohabitation. *European Journal of Population*, 40(1), 11. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10680-024-09697-4>.

<sup>39</sup> Unanue Cuesta, M. C. (2014). Social exclusion and the stigmatization of lesbians. *Procedia - Social and Behavioral Sciences*, 161, 77–81. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.sbspro.2014.12.013>.

<sup>40</sup> Kasproski, David & Fischer, Mirjam & de Vries, Lisa & Kroh, Martin & Kühne, Simon & Zindel, Zaza & Richter, David & Chen, Xiao. (2021). LGBTQI\* people in Germany face staggering health disparities. 10.18723/diw\_dwr:2021-5-1.

topics within school curricula continue to constitute a contentious issue within social and political discourse.<sup>41</sup> Institutional biases at universities and government agencies further perpetuate homophobia often subtly and limit resources dedicated to LGBTQ+ issues. Funding priorities tend to favor religious studies (notably Islamic studies), women's rights, and refugee issues over LGBTQ+ topics.<sup>42</sup> Despite the resources available, societal ambivalence toward openly discussing sexual diversity remains pervasive.<sup>43</sup>

### *Silent Marginalisation*

Legal rights for LGBTQ+ individuals in Germany have advanced due to activism and political advocacy. However, recent political shifts, especially around 2015 under Chancellor Angela Merkel, have marginalized LGBTQ+ voices. Policies favoring large-scale migration from Muslim-majority regions, supported by various political and religious groups, inadvertently suppressed LGBTQ+ visibility.<sup>44</sup> Opposition parties like the AfD emphasized traditional family<sup>45</sup> values and rejected discussions of gender and sexuality, contributing to the systemic marginalization of LGBTQ+ individuals—an act that amounts to an invisible genocide.

The then Chancellor Merkel did not actively promote LGBTQ+ visibility. She voted against gay marriage,<sup>46</sup> indicating a clear stance against LGBTQ+ individuals. After her departure from office, subsequent governments have also failed to take meaningful steps to improve LGBTQ+ visibility. To this day, the situation remains unchanged.

## **Collective Responsibility and Moral Guilt**

### **Questioning Responsibility and Accountability**

Most of the population, including politicians and the heterosexual public, has largely remained silent on the issue. Many do not feel responsible or willing to show compassion towards LGBTQ+ individuals, and there is a reluctance to promote LGBTQ+ visibility openly.<sup>47</sup> This attitude is evident in their behaviour, language, and actions.

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<sup>41</sup> Gegenfurtner, A., & Gebhardt, M. (2017). Sexuality education including lesbian, gay, bisexual, and transgender (LGBT) issues in schools. *Educational Research Review*, 22(1), 215–222. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.edurev.2017.02.001>

<sup>42</sup> See <https://en.dreilinden.org/dreilindens-5th-monitoring-study-publishedgerman-funding-for-lgbtiqa-human-rights-work-in-the-global-south-and-east/> (Accessed September 25, 2025).

<sup>43</sup> OECD (2023).

<sup>44</sup> See <https://www.theguardian.com/world/2015/nov/05/refugee-influx-a-major-opportunity-for-germany-leading-economist-says> (Accessed September 24, 2025).

<sup>45</sup> See Heinemann, I. (2022). Volk and family: National Socialist legacies and gender concepts in the rhetoric of the Alternative for Germany. *Journal of Modern European History*, 20(3), 371–388. <https://doi.org/10.1177/16118944221110713>.

<sup>46</sup> See <https://www.reuters.com/article/world/germanys-merkel-voted-against-gay-marriage-idUSKBN19L0SU/> (Accessed on September 27, 2025).

<sup>47</sup> Korinth, R., Bröning, S., & Martyniuk, U. (2024). Making the Invisible Visible: Experiences of Identity (In)Visibility in Bi + Sexual Individuals in Germany. *Journal of Bisexuality*, 24(4), 508–533. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15299716.2024.2364663>.



The fundamental influences go beyond individual sexual orientation and are embedded in wider societal patterns especially the tendency to regard the actions of the majority as the definitive authority, often considering their perspective as the ultimate standard.<sup>48</sup> This mindset leads to the marginalization of minority groups, dismissing their experiences and existence simply because they are fewer in number. Such awareness cultivates an ongoing, often invisible, tension between the majority and minority groups.

The heterosexual majority frequently perceives itself as privileged and more powerful than the homosexual minority, fostering subtle social tensions that persist over time.<sup>49</sup> Heterosexuals hold the power to influence the lives of homosexuals either positively or negatively<sup>50</sup> and historically, this power has often been wielded in ways that undermine or marginalize the latter.

Given these circumstances, it is understandable if homosexuals feel that heterosexuals should feel some degree of guilt for their actions, behaviors, and words that have contributed to this systemic imbalance and social tension. On one hand, it can be argued that the majority bears primary responsibility, given its historical role in perpetuating discrimination.<sup>51</sup> On the other, it is unjust to assign collective guilt to all heterosexuals, many have been passive or silent witnesses rather than active oppressors. Only those in positions of power who actively perpetrated oppression could be held accountable.<sup>52</sup> Passive complicity, remaining silent or indifferent can be seen as a form of co-responsibility.

### Systemic Heteronormativity and Societal Guilt

The dominant heteronormative framework positions heterosexuality as the societal default, rendering homosexuality dependent on heterosexual acceptance.<sup>53</sup> This systemic dynamic resembles subjugation. Yet, blaming society's laws or structures is different from blaming individuals for their participation in injustice. For centuries, societal norms have been built around heteronormativity,<sup>54</sup> which has limited LGBTQ+ individuals' opportunities to be

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<sup>48</sup> Eisner, L., Hässler, T., Thomas, E., Lizzio-Wilson, M., McGarty, C., & Louis, W. (2025). Does majority support for minority rights impact perceived norms and psychological well-being? An application to the LGBTIQ+ context. *Political Psychology*, epub ahead of print. doi:10.1111/pops.70014, Doney, J. R. (2011). *Majority tyranny or minority power? Impact of direct democracy on same-sex relationship rights* (Undergraduate Honors Capstone Projects No. 77). Utah State University. <https://digitalcommons.usu.edu/honors/77>.

<sup>49</sup> Schope, R. D., & Eliason, M. J. (2000). Thinking versus acting: Assessing the relationship between heterosexual attitudes and behaviors towards homosexuals. *Journal of Gay & Lesbian Social Services: Issues in Practice, Policy & Research*, 11(4), 69–92. [https://doi.org/10.1300/J041v11n04\\_04](https://doi.org/10.1300/J041v11n04_04).

<sup>50</sup> Eisner, Hässler, Thomas, Lizzio-Wilson, McGarty, & Louis, (2025).

<sup>51</sup> Franklin, R. (2011). Warm brothers in the boomtowns of hell: The persecution of homosexuals in Nazi Germany. *Hohonu Journal of Academic Writing*, 9, 56.

<sup>52</sup> Spinner-Halev, J. (2007). From historic to enduring injustice. *Political Theory*, 35(4), 574–597. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0090591707304585>.

<sup>53</sup> Eisner, L., Hässler, T., Thomas, E., Lizzio-Wilson, M., McGarty, C., & Louis, W. (2025). Does majority support for minority rights impact perceived norms and psychological well-being? An application to the LGBTIQ+ context. *Political Psychology*, epub ahead of print. doi:10.1111/pops.70014, Doney, J. R. (2011). *Majority tyranny or minority power? Impact of direct democracy on same-sex relationship rights* (Undergraduate Honors Capstone Projects No. 77). Utah State University. <https://digitalcommons.usu.edu/honors/77>.

<sup>54</sup> Borooah, V. (2021). *Prejudice: Xenophobia, homophobia, and patriarchy in the world* (MPRA Paper No. 113065). University Library of Munich, Germany.

visible: they can conform, withdraw, or accept ongoing marginalization, conditions that can be described as a form of modern “slavery,” in which principles of equality remain largely unfulfilled. Achieving complete acceptance and equality, however, remains a distant perhaps unattainable goal.

### **Embracing Guilt, Tolerance, and Societal Responsibility**

Wrongdoings and feelings of guilt will always nag at; they prevent inner peace. Having that sense of guilt can be beneficial, because remaining immune or indifferent to actions may lead to continued wrongdoings.<sup>55</sup> A small reminder or discomfort can serve as a deterrent, helping to refrain from repeating harmful behaviours. It is not necessary to justify wrongful actions or dismiss guilt, as doing so essentially grants permission to repeat them.<sup>56</sup> A gentle reminder or pinch can guide back to a natural state—one of acceptance rather than discrimination. Further, true acceptance, tolerance, inclusion, and diversity cannot be artificially manufactured; attempting to force these qualities makes them superficial and insincere. Genuine humility, for example, must originate from the soul, an authentic inner feeling rather than from an external effort.

Tolerance is an innate quality within us. It involves a subconscious acceptance, a natural state where we are not even aware that we are tolerating. The ability to accept or tolerate does not stem from external forces; rather, it reflects the soul’s inherent nature—akin to a motherly instinct. Before extending tolerance towards homosexuals, heterosexuals must first cultivate acceptance of their own perceptions and feelings.<sup>57</sup> True tolerance entails understanding, transforming, and accepting with deep sincerity, beyond superficial politeness. This capacity for nurturing and unconditional love is not exclusive to women or mothers; it is a universal soul trait present in everyone, regardless of gender.<sup>58</sup> Heterosexuals should naturally accept homosexuals without deliberate effort. Striving to accept or tolerate can create unnecessary strain and deplete one’s energy. Genuine tolerance is effortless—an innate state that manifests through our genuine application of this quality.

Currently, much emphasis in German media and society is placed on words like “acceptance,” “tolerance,” “inclusion,” “diversity,” and “multiculturalism,” often driven by political motives. The majority of the German population is not fully prepared for or genuinely committed to these ideals at a deep, internal level.<sup>59</sup> For instance, most Germans do not wholeheartedly accept LGBTQ+ individuals from within their hearts; their acceptance and tolerance are often perceived as politically motivated rather than sincere. Consequently, the visibility and genuine integration of LGBTQ+ communities remain limited.<sup>60</sup>

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<sup>55</sup> Luck, T., & Luck-Sikorski, C. (2022). Strategies of adults for dealing with feelings of guilt—Findings from a large web-based survey. *Health Psychology Report*, 11(1), 22–37. <https://doi.org/10.5114/hpr/150501>.

<sup>56</sup> Luck, & Luck-Sikorski, (2022).

<sup>57</sup> Ray, & Parkhill, (2021).

<sup>58</sup> Welwood, J. (1985). On love: Conditional and unconditional. *The Journal of Transpersonal Psychology*, 17(1), 33–40.

<sup>59</sup> OECD (2023).

<sup>60</sup> OECD (2023).

Recognizing the historical and ongoing systemic inequalities faced by LGBTQ+ communities compels us to consider collective guilt and responsibility. While individual attitudes vary, it is the societal endorsement of heteronormativity that sustains discrimination, violence, and invisibility. Heterosexuals, as a societal group, bear an ethical and moral obligation to acknowledge their role whether through passive complicity or active reinforcement. Confronting this reality can inspire societal change, fostering empathy, accountability, and progress toward genuine equality. Feeling guilt, then, is not about blame but about recognizing the societal legacy that continues to marginalize LGBTQ+ individuals. Embracing this responsibility can motivate efforts to challenge ingrained prejudices, reform institutions, and create an environment where diversity is truly accepted and celebrated.

## Conclusion

In conclusion, the journey toward genuine equality and acceptance for LGBTQ+ communities in Germany—and by extension, Western societies demand a profound moral and societal awakening. The underlying histories of repression, systemic heteronormativity, and societal misconceptions continue to shape perceptions and behaviours, often perpetuating invisibility and discrimination against LGBTQ+ individuals. Recognizing the collective responsibility of heterosexual society whether through passive complicity or active reinforcement is essential in fostering genuine change. Embracing moral responsibility and addressing ingrained biases can motivate societal efforts toward empathy, reform, and the creation of an environment that fully accepts and celebrates sexual diversity. Ultimately, understanding and acting upon this shared moral obligation is crucial for progressing toward a more inclusive and equitable society. Only by moving beyond superficial gestures and embracing our shared human dignity can society hope to build an inclusive future where all individuals, regardless of their sexual orientation, can live openly and authentically without fear or invisibility.